

Ur-Nammu, **king of Ur**, formulates the **earliest known written law code**.



c. 2100 BCE

According to **rabbinic tradition**, Moses receives the Torah, **the foundation of Judaic law**, from God on Mount Sinai.



c. 1300 BCE

Greek merchants from Rhodes, having established long-range trade links, develop **a code of international maritime law** widely adopted across **the Mediterranean**.



500–300 BCE

The first law code of the newly established **Roman Republic** is inscribed on **12 bronze tablets** displayed in the Forum.



c. 450 BCE

c. 1750 BCE



King Hammurabi has a **list of 282 laws inscribed** on a stele in the **center of Babylon**.

c. 1046 BCE



King Wu establishes the Zhou dynasty in **China**, claiming the **“Mandate of Heaven”** for his rule.

476–221 BCE



During **China's** Warring States period, **legal systems emerge** based on **Confucianism**, **Daoism**, and **Legalism**.

Humans are a social species. Prehistoric peoples lived in kinship groups and tribes ruled by elders. Over millennia, as civilizations evolved, different systems of government emerged. Rules of conduct, initially based on customs and religious beliefs, became formalized, and laws were codified. In Mesopotamia (now Iraq), the world's first civilization, Ur-Nammu, king of Ur, issued the first known law code 4,000 years ago.

Religion played a major role in early civilizations and inevitably influenced lawmaking. Laws—especially those governing morality or religious observance—were widely believed to have divine authority. According to Jewish tradition, God gave Moses the Torah, the first five books of the Hebrew Bible, which include the Ten Commandments.

These laid the foundations of Mosaic law. The Torah and the later Talmud (a written collection of Jewish oral traditions) are the central sources of Jewish law.

In China, too, rulers claimed they had a divine right to govern. In about 1046 BCE, when Wu, first king of the Western Zhou dynasty, overthrew the ruling Shang dynasty, he declared he had the “Mandate of Heaven,” which could be withdrawn if he failed in his sacred duty to rule justly.

Laws for complex societies

Civilizations across the ancient world, in Mesopotamia, Egypt, India, China, Greece, and Rome, established legal frameworks to organize their increasingly large and complex societies and to ensure the rule of law was properly

administered. To trade with each other, nations also needed mutually accepted rules of commerce. The island of Rhodes, a major mercantile power in the Mediterranean, gave its name to the *Lex Rhodia*, which evolved from around 500 BCE to become the first widely recognized code of maritime law.

As nations became increasingly sophisticated, their thinkers began to consider how their societies might be better organized. In China, from the 5th century BCE, three radically different systems of governing emerged. Confucianism proposed a return to traditional values of virtue and respect, led by example. Daoism advocated the framing of laws in harmony with nature rather than by a ruler's will, while Legalism imposed authoritarian rule, with harsh